## On killing of a Tree – Gieve Patel

It takes much time to kill a tree,
Not a simple jab of the knife

Will do it. It has grown
Slowly consuming the earth,
Rising out of it, feeding
Upon its crust, absorbing
Years of sunlight, air, water,
And out of its leperous hide
Sprouting leaves.

So hack and chop
But this alone wont do it.
Not so much pain will do it.
The bleeding bark will heal
And from close to the ground
Will rise curled green twigs,
Miniature boughs
Which if unchecked will expand again
To former size.

No,
The root is to be pulled out -
Out of the anchoring earth;
It is to be roped, tied,
And pulled out - snapped out
Or pulled out entirely,
Out from the earth-cave,
And the strength of the tree exposed,
The source, white and wet,
The most sensitive, hidden
For years inside the earth.

Then the matter
Of scorching and choking
In sun and air,
Browning, hardening,
Twisting, withering,
And then it is done.

About the poet:

Gieve Patel is himself a doctor, an environmentalist, and he is conscious of food chain and the preservation of it. His *On Killing a Tree* says the same things, only sarcastically. The Earth was put here as a garden with trees for us not to conquer and extinct but to love and live. That way of thought is productive in *On Killing a Tree*.

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GLOSSARY :I

Jab:
Sudden rough blow.
A simple jab of a knife cannot kill a tree.
Leprous hide:
Discolored bark.
The bark of a jabbed tree looks like leprous hide.
Hack:
Cut roughly by striking heavy blows.
When a tree is hacked, the barks bleed but soon they heal
Snapped out:
chopped out.
Bleeding expresses the pain of a tree when the branches of a tree or snapped out.
Scorching and choking:
The drying up of the tree after being uprooted.
Pulling out the tree from the mother earth and scorching and Choking it in the sun and air kill the tree.

Questions :

1. Can a "simple jab of the knife" kill a tree? Why not?
2. How has the tree grow to its full size? List the words suggestive of its life and activity.
3. What is the meaning of "bleeding bark"? What makes it bleed?
4. The poet says "No" in the beginning of the third stanza. What does he mean by this?
5. What is the meaning of "anchoring earth" and "earth cave"?
6. What does he mean by "the strength of the tree exposed"?
7. What finally kills the tree?

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